

ENG 101
Lesson - 41
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Definition:

A summary or precis (French word which means the same as summary) is a **brief** and **clear** statement in a **connected** and **readable shape** of the substance of a longer passage.

i) As a foreign learner of English any examination you take, the examiners are likely to test your ability to read, write and think in English. As summary writing requires all three, it will give you

ii) good practice both in clear writing and clear thinking.

iii) It enables you to express in your own words somebody else's ideas even if you do not agree with those ideas.

Read the passage carefully.

Read passage again. Note the different points it contains. Number the points.

Strike out points not essential to meaning, repetitions, illustrations, anecdotes, comparisons, etc..

Arrange points best possible way.

Write summary – first draft.

Polish the draft

A summary is a **brief** and **clear** statement in a **connected** and **readable** shape of the **substance** of a longer passage.

You noticed five words have been underlined.

In the middle ages people had no ideas of scientific farming. Spare cattle were killed and salted for winter eating. Spices were used a lot. They came from the East. The Turks cut the line of supply. Voyages of exploration were undertaken partly to find spices.

As people in the middle ages had not idea of scientific farming, spare cattle had to be killed and salted for winter eating. This unappetizing meat led to a demand for spices, and one reason for the great voyages of exploration was the shortage of spices when the trucks cut the overland route of their supply. Here are some more examples of phrases that would be better expressed in single words:

of a disagreeable nature

-of a delightful description

in a brief manner

in a stupid way.

of a silly kind

Here are some more examples that show how easy it is to write wordily and also how the wordiness might be avoided.

-Boys whose way of

life is cast in an

- town boys (2)

urban environment (11)

Together with the

addition of (5)

- also (1)

Special attention

- special attention will

will be paid to

be paid to activities

activities with an eye to the

to cultivate initiative

(10)

cultivation of the qualities

of initiative, etc. (18)
Judged in the light of their results (7)
In this connection it (5)
should be said (7)

- Judge by their results (4)
- Here it should be said

Practice 1: Writing Briefly & Clearly:

It is not without interest to observe in connection with the duration of the school term that punishments show a tendency to increase in number as the term progresses. (29)

It is interesting to note that punishments increase as the school term progresses (13)

2. Having regard to the recent increase in the number of cases of malaria in this area it is clearly desirable that the scheme for the provision of more doctors should be put into effect. (34)

The recent increase in the number of malaria cases in this area requires that more doctors should be posted (19)

3. Two men sustained serious bodily injury when their car came into collision with a truck today. (16)

- Today two men were seriously injured when their car collided with a truck. (13)

REPETITION:

People seem sometime to think that what they say twice is more impressive than what they say once. Actually repetition shows weakness not strength.

PRACTICE 2: Avoiding Useless Repetition.

For three months the river is in continuous flood; this state of affairs goes on for the whole of that time without cease.

- For three months the river is in flood.

In the end we eventually agreed to go by the shortest route.

In the end we agreed to go by the shortest route.

Without warning, unexpected, unheralded, the storm broke on us.

- Without warning the storm broke on us.

Putting Ideas Together:

You can do this by subordinating the less to the more important ideas e.g.

-It was quite dark; for the sun had set an hour before and the moon had not yet risen when the thief carefully opened the door of his house and prepared to go about his business. (36)

(Here there are 5 clauses, but it is possible to turn many of them into words or phrases). e.g.

An hour after sunset one dark, moonless night, the thief crept to of his house to go about his business (20 words)

(Here we have 20 words instead of 36 and the meaning so little changed as to be almost the same).

PRACTICE 3:

Shorten the following without losing any of the meaning.

His efforts, although they were the best h could make, ended in failure.

His best efforts failed.

2. Athar came upon a house that was green

Athar came upon a green house.

His horses, which were two in number, he use for the single purpose of playing polo, which he was only able to do on Mondays once in every two weeks.

- He used his two horses for playing polo on Mondays every fortnight.

Four samples of summary writing.

Working conditions in the nineteenth century seem barbaric today: twelve-to-fourteen hour work days; seven day weeks; cramped, unsafe factories; marginal wages, and no legal protection. Yet employers seldom had problems motivating their workers: poverty and unemployment were so widespread that any job was welcome.

- *Widespread poverty and unemployment made nineteenth-century workers willing to put up with terrible working conditions.*

2. Compromise is a common and effective way of coping directly with conflict or frustration. We often recognize that we cannot have everything we want and that we cannot expect others to do just what we would like them to do. We then compromise, deciding on a more realistic solution or goal since an ideal solution or goal is not practical. A young person who loves animals and greatly wishes to become a veterinarian may discover he has less aptitude for biology than he had hoped and that dissecting is so distasteful to him that he could never bring himself to operate on animals. By way of compromise, he may decide to become

an animal technician, a person who works as an assistant to a veterinarian. - *Compromise is a direct way of coping in which we decide on a more realistic solution or goal since an ideal solution or goal is not practical. For example, a person not good in biology may decide to be an animal technician rather than a veterinarian.*

3. All family systems can be categorized into one of two types. The extended family is one in which more than two generations of the same kinship live together either in the same house or in adjacent dwellings. The extended family, which is commonly found in traditional, pre-industrial societies can be very large: It contains 3 generations living together. In contrast, the nuclear family is one in which the family group consists only of the parents and their dependent children. The nuclear family is the usual type in virtually all modern industrialized societies.

-There are two basic types of families. The extended family, which is more than 2 generations living together, is common in pre-industrial societies. The nuclear family, made up of parents and their dependant children, is usual in industrialized societies.

Again, when we feel fear of the dog, we learn to avoid similar situations. Finally, emotions help regulate social interaction. Our observation of other peoples emotional states determines how we respond to them. For example, if we notice that another person is experiencing fear, we may be moved to comfort and reassure him. -

Psychologists have distinguished 3 functions of emotions in our lives. Emotions can prepare us to take action, shape our future behavior, or regulate our social interaction.

